fine by me. At short leg no one expects you to stop a full-blooded shot with your hands. It was one of the few times I stood in that position in the second half of my career.

Although the second Test match at Hamilton the following week was a low-scoring game, in the end it turned out to be a competitive one. On reaching Hamilton, we were shocked to see the track had been watered so much that the pitch was incredibly damp two days before the Test match. Then a lot of rain fell and the covers couldn't be removed to allow it to dry properly. John Wright, our coach, tried inserting a key into the pitch the day before the match and the whole key went in without any effort. It was anything but a good Test wicket.

The dampness delayed the start by four hours on the first day, despite it being bright and sunny in Hamilton. The umpires did the right thing by waiting, as there was no way Test cricket could be played in such conditions. The crowd was getting restless but there was nothing the umpires or players could do. When the match finally started we lost the toss and were sent in to bat first in nigh-on impossible batting conditions. We were bowled out for 99, with no one managing to get in.

I was sitting next to John Wright when Harbhajan was going out to bat, with India six wickets down. John, a New Zealander, had tried telling us that we needed to stay at the wicket and that batting was expected to become easier with time. I told John not to say anything to Harbhajan about digging in. Far better that he should just go out and swing his bat. Time wasn't a factor, as the match was not likely to last the full five days anyway, and whatever runs he managed to score would be valuable. Harbhajan went on to make a quick 20, all in boundaries, and got out trying to defend the ninth ball he faced. His innings gave John a good laugh amidst all the disappointment of the low score. While Bhajji had scored 20 in no time, all the batsmen who had tried to stick around struggled to reach double figures.

New Zealand didn't do any better; in fact, we managed to get a first-innings lead of five runs, which just goes to show the nature of the wicket. In the second innings Rahul and I had a pretty good partnership but neither of us managed to kick on for a big score. After the partnership was broken, wickets fell in a heap and we finally set New Zealand a target of 160.

I must mention the unique feat of Ashish Nehra in this game. He was the first man to bat twice and bowl in two innings on the same day in